

One such admirer happens to be on set. Twenty-four-year-old actor Deep Jangid beams as he is introduced to his co-star, Alia. He recently watched *Gangubai Kathiawadi* in cinemas, and it has left him a fan of 'Alia Ma'am'. "Do you think I can ask her for a photograph?" he asks, after the shoot wraps.

Petite in frame, Alia can appear larger than life on screen. It's hard to take your eyes off her in *Gangubai...*, Sanjay Leela Bhansali's biopic of the mafia queen of Kamatipura. She fills the screen with her presence, and her raspy delivery of dialogue speaks of an assuredness that comes naturally to seasoned actors. *Gangubai...* has catapulted her into elite stardom, with a clip of a little girl dolled up in Gangubai's trademark white, emulating Alia's bossy body language and reciting a dialogue going viral on social media. Enough to sting the once 'Queen' of Bollywood Kangana Ranaut into declaring that Gangubai is a bad influence on children. Too bad.

A month after its release, *Gangubai...* is still running in cinemas and has grossed over Rs 122 crore so far. With it, Alia becomes the first female actor to have two heroine-fronted films (the other being *Raazi*, 2018) enter the Rs 100 crore league. Alia also appears in a small cameo in SS Rajamouli's *RRR*, her first pan-Indian release. The film, she says, thanks to the visionary filmmaker behind it, gives her a toehold in the southern and international markets. The Hindi